November 16, Calcutta to Assensole – I was delayed at Assensole for some days, arranging for the purchase, on the part of the Government, of two elephants, which were to carry my baggage. Two females, the property of the East Indian Railway Company, were selected; a very fine-looking tusker being rejected on account of the uncertainty of his temper, and the fact that he had killed an old woman who went down to the tank where he was bathing. The two which were purchased were called Anarkalli and Peari, the former a sedate old maid, and the latter a skittish, well-shaped, good-tempered young thing of about thirty-five years of age. Since then both these elephants have travelled some thousands of miles with me, and, except that Peari occasionally suffers from fits, they have proved an excellent investment, and have done their work well. [61]

How the Railways in India Inspired a Jules Verne Classic

The East Indian Railway embraces a line from Calcutta to Delhi, with branches to Raneegunge, the Barrackur river, and the Singharron Valley, and a line from Allahabad to Jubbulpore, where it joins the trans-peninsular line from Bombay. Its whole length is 1,338 miles, being 1,138 miles to Delhi, including branches, and about 200 miles for the Jubbulpore line. The line to Jubbulpore strikes off at Allahabad and forms a junction with the Great Indian Peninsula Railway, thereby connecting Bombay with Calcutta and Delhi. [62]

The above report in the *Railway Intelligence* is one of the key contexts in *Around the World in Eighty Days* (French: *Le tour du monde en quatre-vingts jours*), the classic adventure novel by the French writer Jules Verne, published in 1873 .

In the story, Phileas Fogg of London and his newly employed French valet Passepartout attempt to circumnavigate the world in eighty days on a £20,000 wager [the approximate equivalent of £2,221,600 in 2018] set by his friends at the Reform Club. It is one of Verne's most acclaimed works. The story starts in London on Tuesday, 1 October 1872.

In 1869–70, the idea of travelling around the world drew popular attention when three geographical breakthroughs occurred: the completion of the First Transcontinental Railroad in America (1869), the linking of the Indian Railways across the subcontinent (1870) and the opening of the Suez Canal (1869).

Here's a reference to the Indian Railways in *Around the World in Eighty Days* :

'In eighty days,' interrupted Phileas Fogg.

> 'That is true, gentlemen,' added John Sullivan. 'Only eighty days, now that the section between Rothal and Allahabad, on the Great Indian Peninsula Railway, has been opened. [63]

The closing date of the novel, 21 December 1872, was the same date as the last date of its serial publication. As it was being published serially for the first time, some readers believed that the journey was actually taking place—bets were placed, and some railway and ship liner companies lobbied for Verne to appear in the book.

Here is the estimate made by *The Daily Telegraph* :

> From London to Suez via Mont Cenis and Brindisi, by rail and steamboats – 7 days
> From Suez to Bombay, by steamer – 13 days
> From Bombay to Calcutta, by rail – 3 days